When he became chief minister for a second consecutive time in 2021, Pinarayi Vijayan broke a 40-year jinx that had seen his CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front (LDF) and the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) alternate in power. Riding its globally feted management of the COVID-19 pandemic, it dashed the UDF hopes of turning its 19-1 victory in the 2019 general election into local political currency. The LDF even upped its take-home, from 91 to 99 seats in a 140-strong assembly. Kerala finds itself at the same crossroads today—the state again voted overwhelmingly UDF (18 seats) in the 2024 Lok Sabha election. The Congress-led Opposition also delivered a body blow to the LDF in the 2025 local body elections and even wrested the Nilambur assembly seat in a bypoll last year. Can Pinarayi again manage a winning return of serve? Or will 2026 be the end of the road for the 80-year-old CPI(M) strongman? If it's bad news that comes on May 4, it will also dim the lights on the Left in its last remaining bastion in the country.

Party general secretary M.A. Baby does not think much of the odds of that happening. "Local body elections are different; this is for who rules the state," he says. In their bid for a hat trick, Pinarayi and the LDF are building a two-fold narrative. The first is about continuity, progress and the 'Kerala model' of development. The second aims to highlight the Narendra Modi government's alleged discrimination against Kerala, whether it's the denial of financial support for the Wayanad landslide victims or a special financial package for the Vizhinjam seaport, a high-speed rail corridor, or the Kerala iteration of a much-promised All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). "Be it roads, infrastructure, the Wayanad rehabilitation or social security, the Left government has delivered on all the promises it made in 2021. And this is despite the Modi government's best efforts to throttle Kerala financially by denying the state its dues," says Baby.

Pinarayi will once again be leading the LDF campaign, contesting from home constituency Dharmadom, a CPI(M) stronghold in Kannur district. The party has relaxed the two-term cap for legislators to accommodate the octogenarian CM. Riding on the slogan 'Who else but LDF?', the Left coalition intends to showcase the "visible infrastructure it has created". "The Congress and BJP are just repeating their lies," Pinarayi told the



THE INCUMBENT

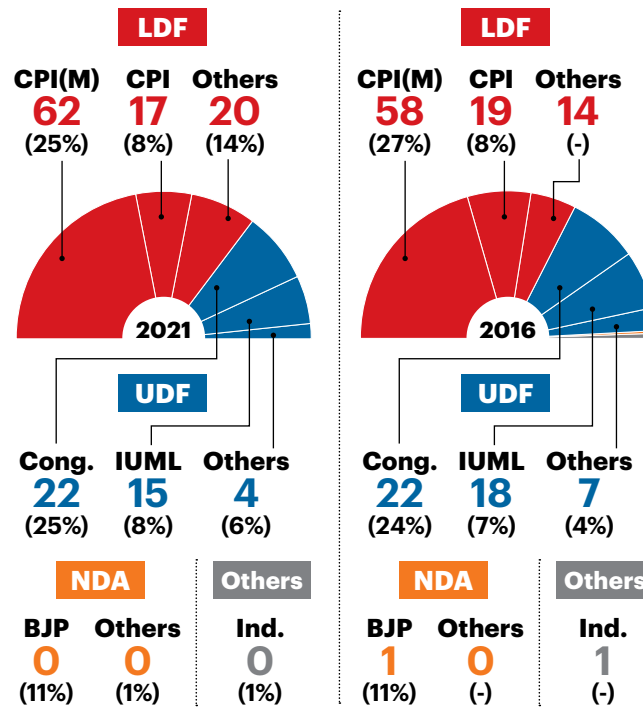
Pinarayi Vijayan, 80, CPI(M)
Chief Minister, Kerala

KEY STRATEGIES

- **Projecting the 'visible infrastructure' development in the state, including the coastal and hill highways, hi-tech schools, water metro and such**
- **Reaching out to the 6.2 million beneficiaries of the social welfare pension schemes of the LDF government**
- **Ensuring the Hindu segment of the Left base, specially Ezhavas, do not shift loyalties. Sections of the community had drifted to the BJP after Ezhava-based outfit Bharat Dharma Jana Sena (BDJS) joined the NDA in 2016**
- **Winning over the Muslim vote in Malabar to ensure extra seats. The community has traditionally been supporters of Congress and IUML but supported the LDF in 2021. The LDF is banking on a section of Muslim votes this time too**

PAST RECORD

Total seats: **140**



Numbers denote seats won; vote share in ()